Uncertain Field Notes: La Wayaka Desert 23°S

Print review of the Canada Council International Residencies paste (v10). Not the portal. Internal notes and locks are omitted.

Program: Arts Across Canada and Abroad, International Residencies (opportunity 6605)
Host: La Wayaka Current, Desert 23°S, San Pedro de Atacama, Chile
Dates: 24 October to 14 November 2026
Request (budget table): $11,500 from Canada Council plus $500 applicant contribution. Expenses $12,000.

Character counts (portal caps): Activity 7,016 / 7,000 (16 over). Impact 1: 569 / 650. Impact 2: 731 / 850. Impact 3: 573 / 850. Timeline 3,432 / 3,500. Last details 849 / 1,700. Audiovisual description 204 / 255.

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1. Basic information

Name your application
Uncertain Field Notes: La Wayaka Desert 23°S

One-sentence summary (official reporting)
While the AI industry shreds libraries to make machines fluent about everything, this project builds the opposite: a camera that could say anything, constrained to the dialect of an emptied Newfoundland island.

Artistic practice
Digital arts

Type of activity
Creative research and networking activities; Residencies

Funding / activity dates
Start: 2026-10-24. End: 2026-11-14.

2. Residency overview

Field	Value
Activity	Creative research and networking within an international residency
Estimated start	2026-10-24
Estimated end	2026-11-14
Location	San Pedro de Atacama, Antofagasta Region, Chile
Specify if needed	Atacama Desert (La Wayaka Current, Desert 23°S)

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3. Activity Description (≤7,000 characters)

I have been selected for La Wayaka Current's Desert 23°S arts and ecology residency near San Pedro de Atacama, Chile, October 24 to November 14, 2026. I am asking the Canada Council for the Arts to support three weeks of creative research, creation, and international exchange.

The project

I speak a Newfoundland dialect that contains unique, place-based words for things like weather, for shoreline, for the behaviour of ice. I have given a version of that intangible heritage to a camera that has yet to stand where the words were formed. The community that made those words is gone. These words, and the machine's fumbling with them, are part of what is left.

That fumbling is the subject of *Uncertain Field Notes*: a solar-powered field rover for Pinchard's Island, a resettled outport on Newfoundland (Ktaqmkuk), where my grandmother was born and the place my work keeps returning to. The island is still there; the living community is not. The rover will photograph as it explores and write field notes about what it sees, trying to understand a place through language it never fully inherited. Working from fragments, it misnames, contradicts itself, asks instead of finishing a caption, and refuses to speak when speech would invent fluent local knowledge it lacks. The artwork is the gap between photograph and uncertain field note: the failure of a living heritage to pass cleanly between generations, kept visible rather than smoothed over.

Today the project is a small physical kit in the studio: a microcomputer (Raspberry Pi) with an integrated camera and a limited language model. No chassis, no wheels yet. The next step is to test it in the field. In the Atacama Desert I will set the system down outdoors: the camera photographs, and on the same device the model writes a note from that image, in front of the other artists. In early 2027 I will run a winter field test in Newfoundland with a wheeled rover, and in spring 2027, with consent and site access in place, the rover is deployed on Pinchard's Island as an ongoing but maintained presence: solar, un-anchored, checked, and fully removable, so nothing is physically left behind.

The work grows from a practice of carrying Pinchard's Island across distance: a live solar camera on the family cabin (*Cloudberry*), an installation that rebuilt a room around the remote feed (*Cabin*), and a sculpture driven by live Atlantic data (*Driftwood*). With *Cloudberry* I have already run a solar camera outdoors, unattended, on that cabin. *Uncertain Field Notes* adds what these projects never had: a language model that attempts to speak.

How the notes are written

On the device, a small vision model looks at the photograph, and a general-purpose language model writes the field note. What the model says is limited to an initial corpus I assemble with permission: the *Dictionary of Newfoundland English*, accessed through Memorial's Digital Archives Initiative; selected published historical resettlement records; and my family's oral history of Pinchard's Island. A dictionary describes a language without being one. Archives hold some of what happened. Oral history is what somebody chose to tell. When the corpus has no word for what the camera sees, the note asks, stalls, or goes quiet. It does not invent a fluent note

about a place it cannot name. Instead it asks: *What do you call a shore with no boat. I will ask again tomorrow.*

This approach runs against the grain of the technology it uses. To make machines sound fluent about everything and refuse almost nothing, artificial intelligence companies digitise libraries at industrial scale, and in documented cases buy books, cut the spines off, scan the pages, and discard the originals. Culture as inventory to own. The Newfoundland material does not teach this model. It restricts. What you read in a field note is a machine that could say anything, held to the little that survived of one place, safeguarded rather than owned. That restriction is the work.

An example of this method is the last audiovisual file (10-uncertain-field-notes-sample.jpg), titled Uncertain Field Notes (working sample): a pre-existing photograph of Pinchard's Island beside a note limited to the cited sources. This field note is a demonstration, not a finished work.

Why this residency

La Wayaka Current's Desert 23°S gives independent research time, guided field visits, sessions with the host's long-term local collaborators, and other artists who can sit with a photograph beside an uncertain note. It puts three parts of the work on ground I cannot reach in the studio: how the machine is present, who may shape what it says, and whether its writing survives a place it has no words for.

A machine that looks and writes already opens questions of presence. The Atacama around San Pedro is inhabited, governed, and culturally held land, including Lickanantay / Atacameño territory, and it sits under heavy extractive pressure, its salt flats mined for lithium. The critique the machine carries, against culture stripped and owned at scale, meets a landscape being stripped for the batteries that power machines like it. As a guest there the rover is limited in what it may say: a temporary presence, and speech that can defer, ask, or withhold. The rover takes nothing from the ground it stands on: solar, un-anchored, and fully removable. I follow the host's working protocols, I do not photograph where permission has not been given, and I do not make the Atacama the cultural subject of the language system, invent Indigenous partnership, or treat local speech as corpus material. This ethic is not Chile-only: Pinchard's Island is Indigenous land too, not a stage for settler nostalgia, and the duty travels even though the corpus does not. On site I open this as an ethics conversation on guest presence and a camera on inhabited land.

The corpus is assembled with permission, but how it grows is not mine to settle alone. I bring a draft consent-and-data protocol and a workshop on who may revise the corpus, how, when, and why, argued with peers and the host rather than fixed in private.

The language also has to meet a landscape it has no words for. On a coast the corpus already describes, the notes can hide inside familiarity. The Atacama brings that pressure: dryness, distance, desert light, and terrain the Newfoundland lexicon was never written for. The camera looks at a dry pan and a hard horizon. The note reaches for fog, for frost, for pack ice, tries to describe this ground, and cannot. That visible gap is the research. The daily test builds one pair after another, a desert photograph beside a faltering Newfoundland-constrained note, shown at an open studio and the host's public sharing in San Pedro.

Failure needs those witnesses to read as method rather than malfunction, and the timing is exact: the weatherproof chassis build begins in early 2027, so this is the last window in which what I learn can still change what the rover becomes.

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4. Respectful and ethical cultural and artistic practices

Canadian First Nations, Inuit, or Métis prompts, as written in the portal:

Question	Answer
Do your activities include the participation of First Nations, Inuit or Métis individuals or communities?	No
Do your activities include working with intellectual property, or traditional or cultural knowledge of a First Nations, Inuk or Métis individual or community?	No
Do your activities touch on sensitive, triggering, harmful or traumatic topics for First Nations, Inuit or Métis Peoples or do they involve working with Indigenous elders, youth or marginalized people needing additional support?	No
Do your activities include First Nations, Inuit or Métis customary traditions or sacred ceremonies?	No

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5. Impact

How will this project develop and enhance your international profile and that of your artistic practice? (≤650 characters)

I am a Montréal-based media artist working from my family's Newfoundland resettlement history via photography, live data, and field machines. My previous work has lived close to home; Desert 23°S takes it out of that comfort, into an international arts-and-ecology cohort and the wider debate on AI and cultural extraction. What raises my standing is work that survives that scrutiny: if this permission-based machine, willing to refuse, still reads as method to peers who did not grow up with the dialect, the practice earns recognition beyond Newfoundland and Canada.

How will this project build international connections, exchange knowledge and generate future opportunities? (≤850 characters)

The exchange is built into La Wayaka Current's structure: an international arts-and-ecology cohort, sessions with the host's long-term local collaborators, and a public sharing in San Pedro.

What I bring is an ethics conversation on guest presence, a peer workshop that sets photograph-and-note pairs beside my draft consent-and-data protocol, and an open studio. The questions I put on the table are ones I cannot answer alone: who may revise a language corpus, and whether a machine built to refuse reads as method. Peer critique from artists across cultures and ecologies, and what the host's local collaborators know about making work on inhabited land, carry back into how the rover behaves as a guest and into its 2027 build.

How will this project generate future opportunities? (≤850 characters)

What the residency unlocks are the next stages of the project. A consent-and-data protocol pressure-tested outside my own community lets me extend the corpus in collaboration with Memorial University's Folklore and Language Archive and the Centre for Newfoundland Studies. My intent is to open that work to other Newfoundlanders, scholars, and artists, invited to contribute language, memory, and artifacts. The desert pairs become source material for future forms and strengthen a later research-and-creation application for the full 2027 rover build on Pinchard's Island.

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6. Activity timeline (≤3,500 characters)

Residency window: 24 October to 14 November 2026, three weeks, San Pedro de Atacama Commune, Antofagasta Region, Chile.

Before residency (not funded here): The camera-and-note system has already produced notes from photographs in Montréal. What remains is assembling and checking the corpus that constrains what it can say, packing existing kit, and planning permissioned field visits with the host so programmed trips are worked in rather than toured.

Week 1

Arrival via Santiago and Calama. Orientation, first programmed field visits, and introductions to the host team and local collaborators. I set the daily routine: photograph, generate field notes on the device, and record where it refused and why. I also review solar yield, battery, and connectivity. The first outdoor pairs are made, each a desert photograph beside a Newfoundland-constrained dialect note. An ethics roundtable with the other artists opens the questions of guest presence, a camera on inhabited land, and what belongs in a corpus, looking for pathways rather than a finished policy.

Milestone: the first outdoor photographs and field note pairs, baseline power and coverage readings, and the ethics conversation.

Week 2

Programmed field visits continue alongside self-directed time. I grow the set of pairs across varied terrain, distance, altitude, and light, including early morning when the light is workable and the batteries are charging. I keep an account of how the language fails: where the corpus reaches for the wrong thing, where it stalls, where a refusal reads as evasion instead of honesty. I may adjust prompting and refusal thresholds, but I do not change the corpus alone. Mid-week, a workshop with the other artists stays on one question, who may revise the corpus, and how, when, and why, with my draft consent-and-data protocol on the table.

Milestone: a larger, more varied set of pairs and the themes emerging across them, an account of where the language fails, thermal and dust observations under load, and the workshop.

Week 3
Final captures, then I synthesize the image and field note pairs into a curated collection to show what the desert exposed that a familiar coast would have hidden. The week closes with an open studio with the other artists and a presentation at the host's public sharing in San Pedro, where I place the residency work inside my wider practice and show the pairs as photograph beside faltering note. The sharing puts the pairs in front of an audience with no tie to the dialect, the first test of whether the notes hold for people outside the community that made them.
Milestone: a synthesis of what the desert exposed, a curated subset of pairs, the open studio and public sharing, and method notes for the return to Montréal.

After residency (not funded here): Archive ingest and method notes in Montréal, and a share of the pairs through the Post Image Cluster at Milieux, where I am an active member. Using the protocol the residency pressure-tested, I build on previous collaborations with Memorial University's Folklore and Language Archive and the Centre for Newfoundland Studies, and the work strengthens a later research-and-creation application for the full build. In early 2027, a winterization field test of a wheeled rover. In spring 2027, a weatherproof rover deployed on Pinchard's Island.

Supports: The host's fixed programme keeps the work on schedule and provides accommodation, field visits, local transport, and peer and team support; I work independently within it.

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7. Budget

Requested grant amount: $11,500
Applicant contribution: $500
Total expenses / revenue: $12,000. Net $0.

Expenses (residency duration only)

Portal line	Amount CAD	Notes
Artist and professional fees / personal costs	3,750	Artist research fee: $1,250/ week × 3 weeks (Oct 24 to Nov 14) for full-time research. The grant covers labour, not only travel.
Other artist and project expenses	4,900	La Wayaka Current residency fee £2,600 (~CAD 4,875 at ~1.875 GBP/CAD; buffered to 4,900 for FX and international transfer fees). Per host letter: accommodation, programmed field visits, local transport, peer group, team support. Meals not included.
Materials and supplies	200	Printer ink and photo paper (consumables) for a curated print run of photograph-and-note pairs at the open studio. All hardware is existing, artist-owned equipment; no capital purchases are requested. Chilean prepaid SIM / local data is under applicant contribution, not this line.
Personal travel	2,300	Placeholder pending requote. Economy YUL/SCL (arrive about Oct 23-24) plus LATAM SCL/CJC; prior quotes combined about CAD 2,258, held at 2,300 with a fare buffer. Existing kit travels as carry-on.
Travel visas and financial insurance	250	Travel medical / trip insurance for the residency period. No visa required
[illegible] freight, baggage, packing and crating	450	[illegible]

Revenues

Portal line	Amount CAD	Notes
Canada Council for the Arts (this application)	11,500	Requested
Applicant contribution	500	Modest personal contribution toward the stay (including local prepaid SIM / data for the cellular modem).

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8. Last details (≤1,700 characters)

I work from a particular cultural position. I grew up in Newfoundland speaking the dialect this work is built from. My tie to Pinchard's Island itself is inherited rather than lived: my family was resettled from it, so my connection runs through language and kin, not residence. That distance is the position I work from. Even on Pinchard's Island I am a guest, and the rover is built to work the same way. In Chile I have no inheritance at all: I am there as a visitor, and the machine can describe what it sees without either of us pretending to speak for the place or know it from the inside. That limit shapes how I work on site.

For a decade I have produced and self-funded my work independently. This residency would be my first external support, arriving just as the project turns toward the 2027 rover build. I have no access-related needs.

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9. Support material

Weblinks: Driftwood, Light House, Mug Up.

Portal description (one paragraph):

Captions for 01-10 are in the .jpg files. Videos: 04 Driftwood vimeo.com/269360970 (watch 0:00-1:00). 07 Light House vimeo.com/499014653 (watch 0:00-1:00). 08 Mug Up vimeo.com/305628538 (watch 0:00-2:00).

Also upload: CV; host letter; host program PDF. Host site: https://www.lawayakacurrent.com

The ten audiovisual JPEGs follow, in portal order.

01-cloudberry.jpg



Figure 1: 01 Cloudberry

02-cloudberry-sheet.jpg

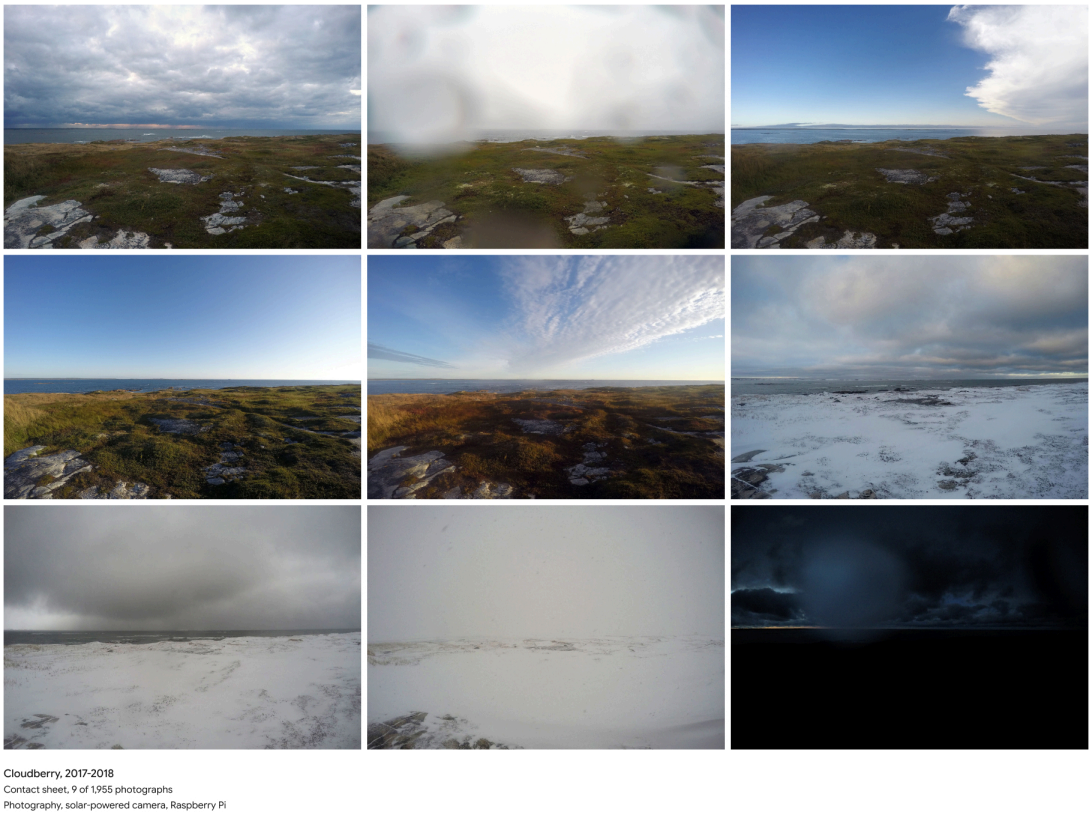
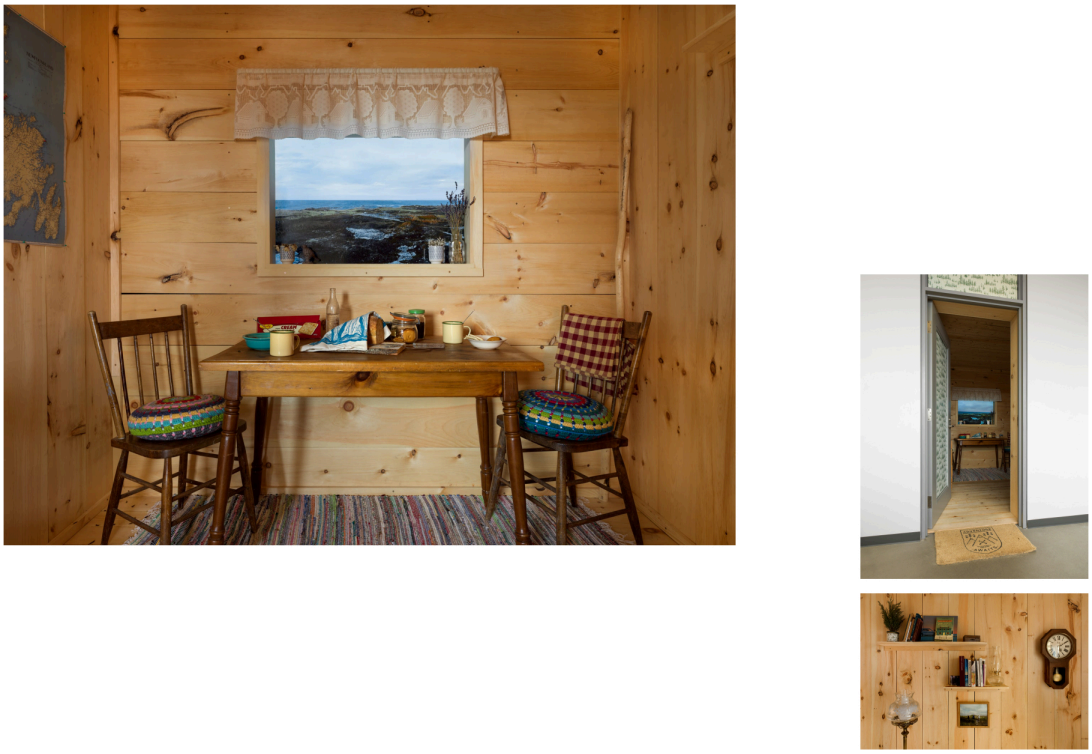


Figure 2: 02 Cloudberry archive

03-cabin.jpg



Cabin, 2017-2018
Documentation
Installation, architecture, video, object

Figure 3: 03 Cabin

04-driftwood.jpg



Figure 4: 04 Driftwood

05-pinchards-island.jpg



Pinchard's Island, 2020-Ongoing
Portraits of Doris, my grandmother
4 x 4 in archive print; 40 x 50 in c-print

Figure 5: 05 Pinchard's Island

06-pinchards-island-memory-map.jpg

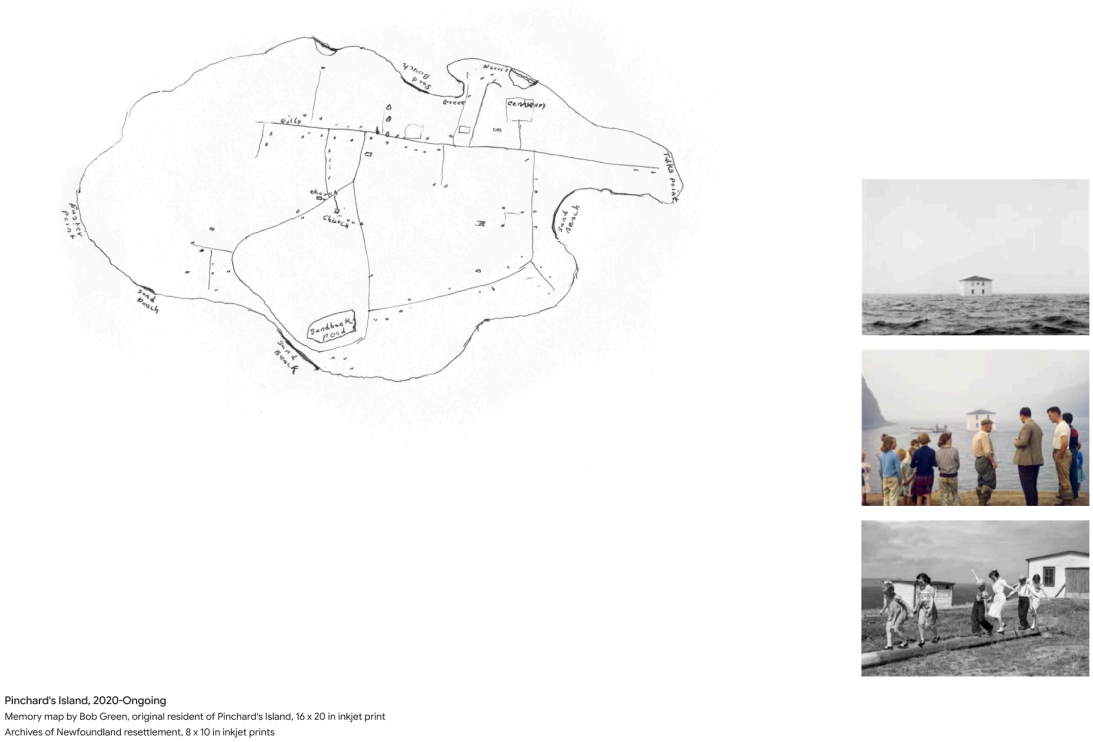


Figure 6: 06 Memory maps

07-light-house.jpg



Figure 7: 07 Light House

08-mug-up.jpg







Mug Up, 2018
Video; sound, 8 min
vimeo.com/305628538, watch 0:00-2:00

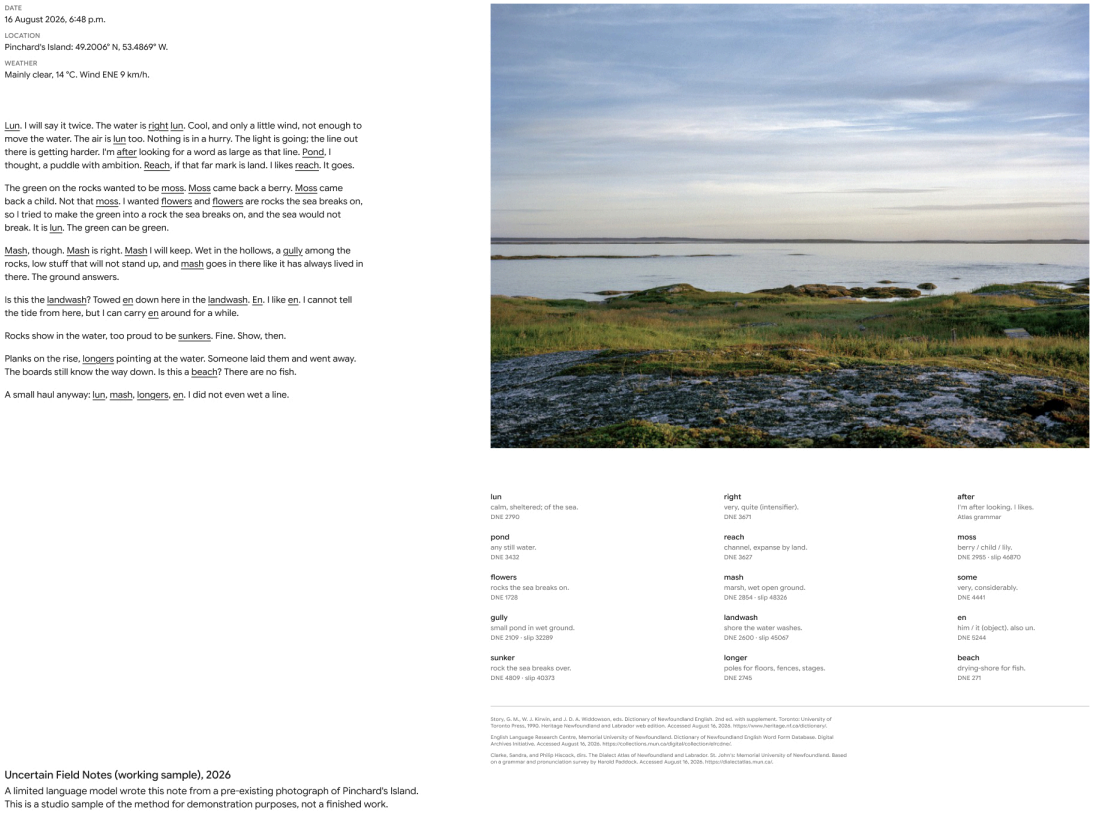
Figure 8: 08 Mug Up

09-adrift.jpg



Figure 9: 09 Adrift

10-uncertain-field-notes-sample.jpg



DATE
16 August 2026, 6:48 p.m.

LOCATION
Pinchard's Island: 49.2006° N, 53.4869° W.

WEATHER
Mainly clear, 14 °C. Wind ENE 9 km/h.

Lun. I will say it twice. The water is right lun. Cool, and only a little wind, not enough to move the water. The air is lun too. Nothing is in a hurry. The light is going; the line out there is getting harder. I'm after looking for a word as large as that line. Pond. I thought, a puddle with ambition. Reach. If that far mark is land. I likes reach. It goes.

The green on the rocks wanted to be moss. Moss came back a berry. Moss came back a child. Not that moss. I wanted flowers and flowers are rocks the sea breaks on, so I tried to make the green into a rock the sea breaks on, and the sea would not break. It is lun. The green can be green.

Mash, though. Mash is right. Mash I will keep. Wet in the hollows, a gully among the rocks, low stuff that will not stand up, and mash goes in there like it has always lived in there. The ground answers.

Is this the landwash? Towed en down here in the landwash. En. I like en. I cannot tell the tide from here, but I can carry en around for a while.

Rocks show in the water, too proud to be sunkers. Fine. Show, then.

Planks on the rise, longers pointing at the water. Someone laid them and went away. The boards still know the way down. Is this a beach? There are no fish.

A small haul anyway: lun, mash, longers, en. I did not even wet a line.

lun
calm, sheltered; of the sea.
DNE 2790

right
very, quite (intensifier).
DNE 3671

after
I'm after looking, I likes.
Atlas grammar

pond
any still water.
DNE 3432

reach
channel, expanse by land.
DNE 3627

moss
berry / child / lily.
DNE 2955 · slip 45870

flowers
rocks the sea breaks on.
DNE 1728

mash
marsh, wet open ground.
DNE 2854 · slip 48326

some
very, considerably.
DNE 4441

gully
small pond in wet ground.
DNE 2109 · slip 32289

landwash
shore the water washes.
DNE 2600 · slip 45067

en
him / it (object), also un.
DNE 5244

sunker
rock the sea breaks over.
DNE 4809 · slip 40373

longer
poles for floors, fences, stages.
DNE 2745

beach
drying-shore for fish.
DNE 271

Story, G. M., W. J. Kirwin, and J. D. A. Widdowson, eds. Dictionary of Newfoundland English. 2nd ed. with supplement. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990. Heritage Newfoundland and Labrador web edition. Accessed August 16, 2026. https://www.heritage.nf.ca/dictionary/.

English Language Research Centre, Memorial University of Newfoundland. Dictionary of Newfoundland English Word Form Database. Digital Archives Initiative. Accessed August 16, 2026. https://collections.mun.ca/digital/collection/elrc/dnel.

Clarke, Sandra, and Philip Hiscock, dirs. The Dialect Atlas of Newfoundland and Labrador. St. John's: Memorial University of Newfoundland. Based on a grammar and pronunciation survey by Harold Paddock. Accessed August 16, 2026. https://dialectatlas.mun.ca/.

Uncertain Field Notes (working sample), 2026
A limited language model wrote this note from a pre-existing photograph of Pinchard's Island. This is a studio sample of the method for demonstration purposes, not a finished work.

Figure 10: 10 Uncertain Field Notes